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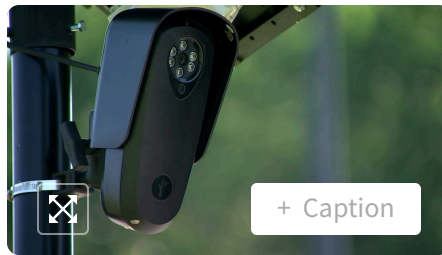
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LOCAL

# Legal concerns raised as WA license plate data is shared with federal agencies



By **KIRO 7 News Staff**  
October 22, 2025 at 9:26 pm  
PDT



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October 22, 2025 at 9:26 pm  
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WASHINGTON — Automated License Plate Readers (ALPRs) have become a popular tool for law enforcement agencies across the country.

However, the amount of information collected by ALPRs has become a source of controversy, particularly in Washington State.

The information collected by ALPRs can be shared with federal agencies such as the U.S. Border Patrol and Immigration and Customs Enforcement (ICE).

Sometimes this information is shared without local agencies being aware that this data is accessible to the federal government.

**The University of Washington Center for Human Rights released a report** examining which law enforcement agencies in Washington are using ALPRs.

They review data from agencies, specifically those that used the ALPR, Flock Safety.

The study reviewed where and with whom they are sharing that information.

During research for the report, it was discovered that several Washington law enforcement agencies had shared ALPR data with Border Patrol and ICE.

This open access has raised questions about compliance with state laws, both knowingly and unknowingly.

According to the report, eight law enforcement agencies had shared information directly with federal agencies.

The report named police departments in Arlington, Auburn, Lakewood, Richland, Sunnyside, Wenatchee, Yakima, and the Benton County Sheriff's Office as doing so as of 2025.

Federal agencies also gained access to data from 10 Washington law enforcement agencies through "backdoor" channels.

Backdoor access allowed the agencies to obtain data even when local agencies had said they wouldn't share it.

There were also instances of "side-door" access.

With side-door access, local agencies searched their own collected data to provide information.

This information could be handed over to out-of-state law enforcement agencies—and, in some cases, to ICE and Border Patrol.

Many advocates argue that this kind of information sharing poses a threat to immigration and reproductive rights.

In one instance, a police officer in Texas accessed information on a woman who had performed a self-managed abortion.

Authorities considered using that information to press charges against her.

In Texas, people can be prosecuted for having, performing, or assisting with an abortion.

There are also concerns about accuracy.

The report noted differences between the list of agencies that can access a network and the actual number of agencies using it.

Flock Safety's founder and CEO, Garrett Langley, was asked about these issues with information sharing between agencies.

He stated that the sharing of local data is between users and their choice of whom they decide to share that information with.

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